

INTRO TO

FUTURES

IN 1
HOUR

FACILITATOR'S
GUIDE



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PROJECT BACKGROUND

This activity introduces participants to some of the fundamental futures thinking (aka strategic foresight) tools and methodologies and helps participants learn by doing quickly in one hour. Participants learn how to think 10, 50 or even 1000 years ahead and make it actionable for today. This activity demonstrates how futures can be used to think creatively and critically about the long-term in order to make better decisions, understand changing human values and create preferable futures. The practice of strategic foresight, which is another name for futures, combines decades of research and expertise in design and strategy to bring useful insights for participants, help them navigate an increasingly uncertain and volatile future, and achieve long-term success through resilience.

We believe that everyone can be a futurist. It's a toolset and mindset that everyone can have.

SETUP

Overestimate and bring plenty of copies of both the workbook and worksheet so participants don't have to share.

Print the worksheet on 8x11 OR 11x17 double-sided paper.

Print the workbook on single 8x11 paper OR on double-sided 11x17 paper collated and stapled like a book.

The workshop space should be configured so that participants can easily work in pairs.

Estimate 1.5 hours for an introduction, the exercise and then Q&A on the backend.

If working with a very large group, estimate 2 hours so you can have more flexibility to help them as they go and have a longer debrief with them at the end.

Consider setting up a texting poll to survey the group at the beginning and end of the session. Otherwise, use large post-its to do a quick retrospective at the end.

Be sure to setup the room according to the group size and bring a projector screen, mic as needed and extra pens or hand toys.

KICKOFF

“To get started you need the workbook, worksheet, a partner and a pen. You will record all your answers on the worksheet and not the workbook, which is your guide.

We are going to spend the next hour leading you and your partner through a series of steps to help you break down the future of Ice Cream or a topic of your choice. We’d recommend you not pick a topic too challenging for today. Save that for later. So you could pick Ice Cream, Marketing, Coffee, Love Life, etc.

By the end of today’s session, we will have helped you explore different critical uncertainties impacting that future, explored resulting scenarios and then determine the preferable one and what actions it implies you need to take today.

So quickly pair off with someone next to you.”

Be sure to state the objectives and tie them together again at the end of the session.

You can also poll the group for:

- Was this what they were expecting?
- How many are familiar with futures work?
- How many have had a futures role? Or knew someone who did?

Capture their roles in their organizations when applicable.

STEP 1

“Okay, quickly determine the Future of X you want to tackle with your partner. Both of you list this on your worksheet. The time horizon will be 10 years from now. You’ll be working collaboratively with your partner until Step 6.”

- Encourage them not to pick another Future of X topic. Typically other topics become too complex for this 1 hour activity.
- Provide examples as it relates to the Future of X as they go to help them make sense of the individual activities faster.
- Provide organizational or industry examples as you go to help them contextualize the content further as well.

GETTING STARTED

WHAT IS FUTURES?
It is tuning into society's undisclosed motives, aspirations and preferences in order to see and pursue opportunities that might otherwise be unavailable to the imagination.

WHAT TOOLS DO I NEED?
This exercise will teach you the basics of some tools that futurists use to think critically and creatively about the future. You will need this booklet, the provided worksheet and a partner for the next hour. Fill out the worksheet as you each progress to save time and make the activity easier.

GRAB YOUR WORKSHEET

STEP 1
Time: 2 min

Your goal is to imagine alternative futures of (insert topic on your worksheet) in the next 10+ years.

HINT:
You can choose any topic with your partner, but it helps to start with something simple like "ice cream."

STEP 2

“Now take 5 minutes to discuss with your partner and list all the main stakeholders that are most involved and/or impacted in your Future of X domain.

For example, customer / employees / government / consumers / distributors, etc.

And then circle the group who’s perspective you want to explore in the next hour. It doesn’t really matter which one you select since we’re just practicing, so pick one that interests you the most.”

You’ll have to remind them to circle the Main Stakeholder and explain that it is their perspective they are most interested in as they move forward.

WHO WILL CARE?

STEP 2

Time: 5 min

Discuss and list on your worksheet the main stakeholder groups most involved / impacted in this domain.

Circle the group whose future you are most interested in. From now on your job is to step into the shoes of this group. We will call this group the **Main Stakeholder**.

A

B

C

D

E

STEP 3

Time: 10 min

Discuss and list on your worksheet as many **critical uncertainties*** as possible including their extremes as it relates to the future of your selected topic across the following STEEP (social, technological, economic, environmental, political) categories.

*A critical uncertainty is a factor that could significantly impact your future one way or the other. It could have a transformative, disruptive or evolutionary impact on that future. For example, for the future of the workplace:

Uncertainty Name	Extreme A	Ext	Extreme B
Staffing Resources	Skills		Human

STEP 3

“Now, with your partner, list as many critical uncertainties as possible thinking across all the STEEP categories listed. A critical uncertainty is a factor that could significantly impact your future one way or the other. It could have a transformative, disruptive or evolutionary impact on that future. You’ll need to capture the extremes of that uncertainty. For example, if “staffing resources” is the future uncertainty, the extremes are “Humans vs. Robots.” You can use the STEEP framework to help you think through these. STEEP stands for Societal, Technological, Environmental, Economic and Political. **You have 10 minutes.**”

It is helpful if you provide a couple of examples and help them list the critical uncertainties and their extremes the correct way. This step is the most challenging of all of them so be ready to assist the group and give them a little more time if needed. You can also create this list as a large group together if everyone is tackling the same Future of X.

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Uncertainty Name	Extreme A	(vs)	Extreme B

STEP 4

“Now, with your partner, pick the two uncertainties that could have the most impact on your future and list them on your worksheet. List the extremes on both the X and Y axis’. **You have 3 minutes.** For example, you both may decide that staffing and the product portfolio are the most impactful in your future.”

If the teams are struggling with the selection process, remind them to pick one that they think is most interesting, since we’re just practicing. You’ll need to remind them where to put the words in the 2X2.

“Congrats you have now created four scenarios that you will explore further as we progress.”

WHAT ARE THE SCENARIOS?

STEP 4
Time: 3 min

Discuss and pick the top **two critical uncertainties** that could **most** significantly impact your future one way or the other. Write the uncertainties and their corresponding extremes on your worksheet.

Extreme A1: _____

Extreme B1: _____

Extreme A2: _____

Extreme B2: _____

Uncertainty #1

Uncertainty #2

STEP 5
Time: 2 min

Each quadrant (area of the square) represents four unique scenarios.

A) Discuss for a moment what each of these scenarios might mean and which scenario would be **most and least preferred to the Main Stakeholder**.

B) Mark on your worksheet the most preferred scenario with a 😊 and the least preferred with a ☹️.

C) Assign randomly the 😊 and ☹️ scenarios to each player.

STEP 5

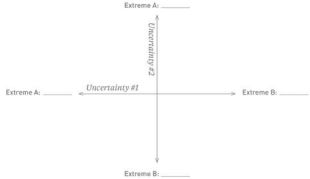
“With your partner, quickly identify the most and least preferred future to your Main Stakeholder that you selected in Step 2. Put a happy face in the preferred quadrant and a frowny face in the least preferred quadrant. Randomly assign these two scenarios to each of you. **You have 2 minutes.**”

You are now going to explore those assigned futures individually before sharing your insights again in several steps.”

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STEP 6

“Now, individually, list on your worksheet under step 6, all the stakeholders from step 2 in decreasing order of agency per your chosen scenario. Agency means who has the most power and influence or control in your scenario. For example, consumers may have all the power in your scenario. In that case, they will be listed first in the list. Government might have the least agency and they will be listed last. **You have 3 minutes.**”

You will need to remind them of the list of stakeholders they created in step 2 and to continue to work independently on steps 6-10. Their answers will be different.

WHO'S IN CHARGE?

STEP 6
Time: 3 min

Individually, list on your worksheet all the stakeholders from Step 2 in **decreasing order of agency*** per your assigned scenario.

*The stakeholder listed #1 has the most power/influence/control in your scenario. The stakeholder listed #5 has the least.

1

2

3

4

5

STEP 7
Time: 5 min

Read the list of universal values below that guide human behavior and identify **what value guides each stakeholder** the most in your scenario. List the selected value next to each stakeholder on your worksheet (choose one value per stakeholder).

- **Power** - having social status, prestige, control or dominance over people / resources
- **Achievement** - personal success through demonstrating competence, having influence
- **Indisgence** - enjoying life, pleasure and self-gratification
- **Novelty** - seeking excitement, variety and challenge in life
- **Self-direction** - independent thought, freedom to be creative and curious
- **Universalism** - understanding and appreciation for the welfare of all people and nature, a world at peace
- **Benevolence** - preservation and enhancement of the welfare of people with whom one is in frequent personal contact, helpful, loyal, honest
- **Tradition** - respect and commitment to the culture and ideas of traditional culture or religion
- **Conformity** - restraint of actions likely to upset or violate others or social norms, self-disciplined
- **Security** - safety, harmony and stability of society, relationships and self

1

*Source: Adapted from G. J. Schwartz (2005)

10

STEP 7

“Now read the list and descriptions of universal values that guide human behavior and then assign the value that guides and motivates each stakeholder the most in your chosen scenario. For example, the government may be guided most by power. Different stakeholders can share the same future values, but you must select one value per stakeholder that you think represents the stakeholder most accurately. **You have 5 minutes.**”

Remind them to write these next to the corresponding stakeholders on the worksheet.

WHO'S IN CHARGE?

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1

*Source: Adapted from S. D. Schwartz (2007)

2

STEP 8

“Now, still individually, think through the behaviors of each stakeholder group in the same order you just listed and the subsequent actions each group would take to maintain or improve their position.

For example, motivated by power, the government would maintain its position by regulating distribution even more. Given this, what would the next stakeholder in the list do? **You have 5 minutes.**”

When completed, remind them that they now have crafted narratives of those future worlds and scenarios.

WHAT'S THE STORY?

STEP 8

Time: 5 min

Individually, answer these questions on your worksheet to help describe the **behavior of each stakeholder group** in the same order of agency as you listed in step 6.

1. This stakeholder group maintains its position in this scenario by _____
(describe behavior)
2. Given the above, this stakeholder group maintains its position in this scenario by _____
3. Given the above, this stakeholder group maintains its position in this scenario by _____
4. Given the above, this stakeholder group maintains its position in this scenario by _____
5. Given the above, this stakeholder group maintains its position in this scenario by _____

STEP 9

Time: 5 min

You now have a basic description of what takes place in your scenario. Take 1 minute to **name your scenario** on your worksheet. Use two words at most. It can be sarcastic, serious or both. Then share your scenario description with your partner.

Scenario Name: _____

Notes: _____

STEP 9

“Now quickly name your scenario. It can be funny, sarcastic, serious or whatever you prefer and it should not exceed two words. The best combination is Adjective + Noun, but you can use whatever you want (e.g., ‘Networked Nirvana’). Then share and describe your scenario to each other through the eyes of your respective Main Stakeholder. **You have 5 minutes.**”

WHAT'S THE STORY?

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Time: 5 min

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1. This stakeholder group maintains its position in this scenario by _____
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2. Given the above, this stakeholder group maintains its position in this scenario by _____
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Scenario Name: _____

Notes:

STEP 10

“Individually again, based on your scenario narrative, quickly draw some experiences, products or services that could exist in your future. For example, you could draw a picture of a new distribution ecosystem or a new type of ice cream, etc. Use pictures not words. **You have 5 minutes to draw and then 5 minutes to share your results with your partner.**”

WHAT COULD IT LOOK LIKE?

STEP 10
Time: 10 min

You now have all the components to imagine what the future might look like. On your workbook, take 5 minutes to individually draw **three ideas of fictional future experiences** (e.g., products, services, interactions) that could exist in your ☺ or ☹ assigned future. Use pictures, not words.

In the remaining 5 minutes, share your ideas with your partner.

Notes:

STEP 11

“Finally, together, discuss and list on your worksheet the ‘So What’ for the Main Stakeholder that you identified in step 2 if any of this happened. How do they accelerate the preferred future? How do they prevent the undesirable, etc.? **You have 10 minutes to discuss.**”

SO WHAT...

STEP 11
Time: 10 min

Discuss and describe on your worksheet the “so what” for the **Main Stakeholder** you identified in step 2.

1. What abilities and/or resources would the Main Stakeholder need to accelerate the ☺ future? _____
2. What abilities and/or resources would the Main Stakeholder need to prevent the ☹ future? _____
3. What does the Main Stakeholder need to watch out for to know which future is unfolding? _____
4. What does the Main Stakeholder need to do tomorrow to prepare for the unknown future? _____

LET'S ALL BE FUTURISTS

You now have the basic skills to become a futurist. Here are some takeaway questions to ponder:

- In your community of practice (organization, city, volunteer, etc.) who do you **need to involve** in this exercise?
- What can you glean from the **other scenarios** that you did not explore today?
- How would all the other **stakeholder groups** influence your success in the future?
- What **values** today do you think would be the most difficult to change?
- What would it take to **test** one of your ideas in real life?

SPARKS GROVE FUTURES
www.sparksgrove.com futures@sparksgrove.com

CONCLUSION

“You now have the fundamentals of being a futurist. Congrats. Hopefully you can see how you can apply this in your current situation or organizations moving forward to help make sense of long-term futures.”

Consider polling the group:

- How did that feel?
- Did you find your mind shifting into a different mode to think about long-term futures?
- What did you like about the exercise?
- What did you find confusing?
- Any other questions for us?

“We are happy to chat more and provide other training opportunities and materials to help make this real for you both personally and professionally.”